

Objectives

- To process a large-scale dataset of Philippine food prices (2.5 million rows) and environmental data to identify price drivers.
- To implement advanced feature engineering including rolling weather averages and price momentum lags.
- To develop a Random Forest model for price prediction and categorize regions based on food security risk levels.

Tasks Completed

Feature Engineer

- **Tasks:** Creation of environmental and temporal features.
- **Description:**
 - Engineered Rolling Weather Features: Calculated 14-day and 30-day moving averages for precipitation (PRECTOTCORR) and temperature (T2M), grouped per region.
 - Developed Lagged Price Features: Created 7-day and 14-day price lags and a '7-day price momentum' feature (price_momentum_7d) per region-commodity pair to capture market speed and direction.
 - Implemented One-Hot Encoding (OHE): Applied `pd.get_dummies()` to 17 region and 85 commodity columns, generating 102 binary categorical variables for model input.
- **Screenshot/Code Snippet:**

```
# — 1-A Rolling weather features (per region) —————
weather_group = df.groupby('adm1_name')

for col in ['PRECTOTCORR', 'T2M']:
    df[f'{col}_roll14'] = (
        weather_group[col]
        .transform(lambda x: x.rolling(14, min_periods=1).mean())
    )
    df[f'{col}_roll30'] = (
        weather_group[col]
        .transform(lambda x: x.rolling(30, min_periods=1).mean())
    )

print('Weather rolling features:', [c for c in df.columns if 'roll' in c])
```

✓ 0.6s

```
# — 1-B Lagged price features (per region × commodity) —————
price_group = df.groupby(['adm1_name', 'cm_name'])

for lag in [7, 14]:
    df[f'mp_price_lag{lag}'] = (
        price_group['mp_price']
        .transform(lambda x: x.shift(lag))
    )

df['price_momentum_7d'] = df['mp_price'] - df['mp_price_lag7']
print('Lagged/momentum features:', [c for c in df.columns if 'lag' in c or 'momentum' in c])
✓ 1.8s

Lagged/momentum features: ['mp_price_lag7', 'mp_price_lag14', 'price_momentum_7d']

# — 1-C One-Hot Encoding —————
df_encoded = pd.get_dummies(
    df,
    columns=['adm1_name', 'cm_name'],
    drop_first=False,
    dtype=int
)

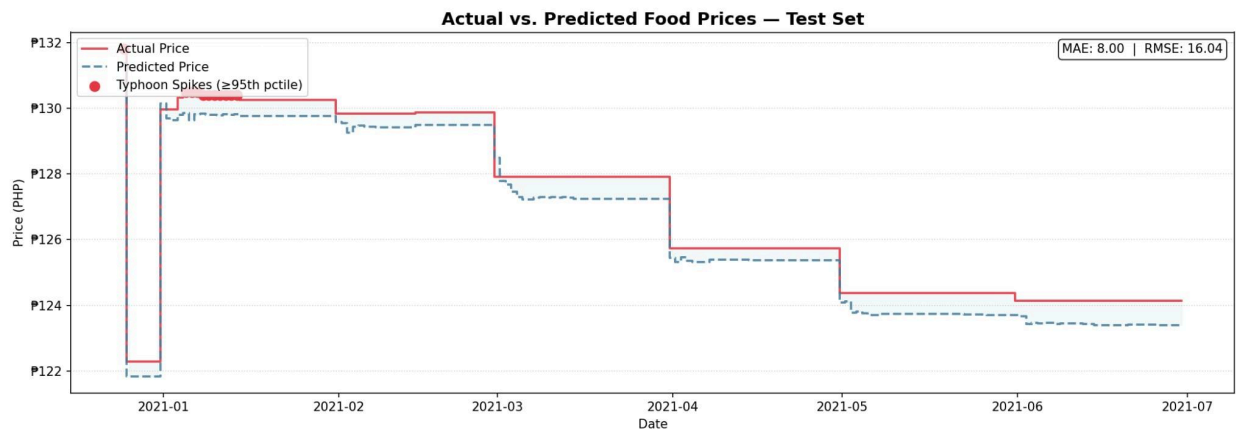
ohe_cols = [c for c in df_encoded.columns
             if c.startswith('adm1_name_') or c.startswith('cm_name_')]
print(f'Shape after OHE: {df_encoded.shape} | OHE columns added: {len(ohe_cols)}')
✓ 3.7s
```

Tasks to be Completed

- Explore additional features like "Holiday/Seasonality" flags to see if they improve price spike predictions

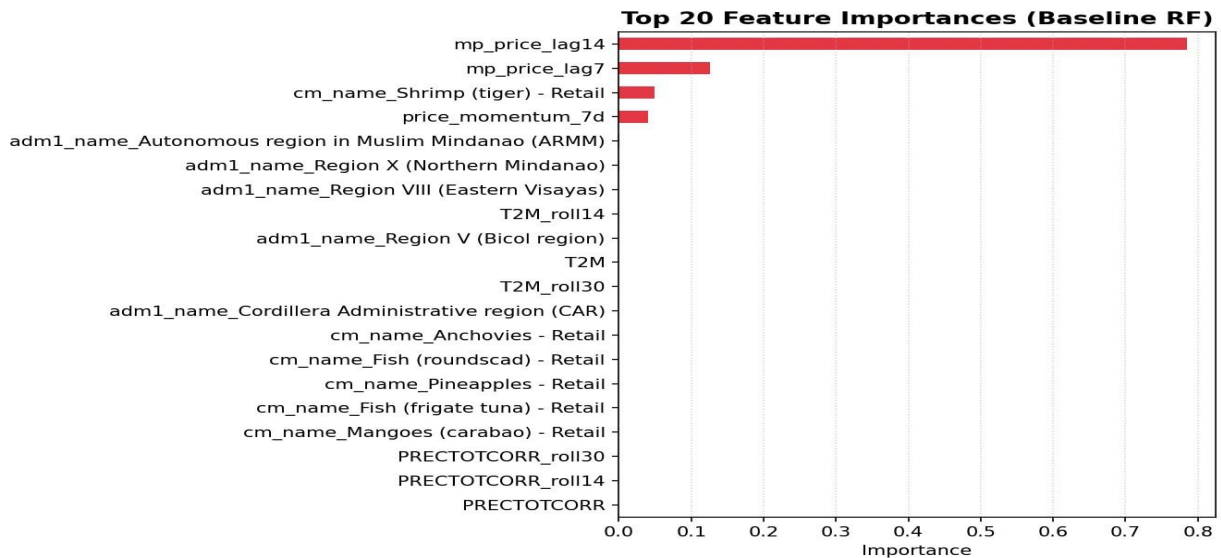
Results and Analysis

1. Price Prediction — Baseline Random Forest



The Baseline Random Forest model was tested on data covering January to July 2021, achieving a MAE of ₱8.00 and RMSE of ₱16.04. As shown in the figure, the predicted price (dashed blue) generally follows the trend of the actual price (solid red) but consistently lags behind during sharp price transitions — particularly during the early January 2021 spike and the step-down drops in March and April 2021. This lag indicates that the baseline model underreacts to sudden market changes driven by typhoon events or supply disruptions.

2. Feature Importance Analysis

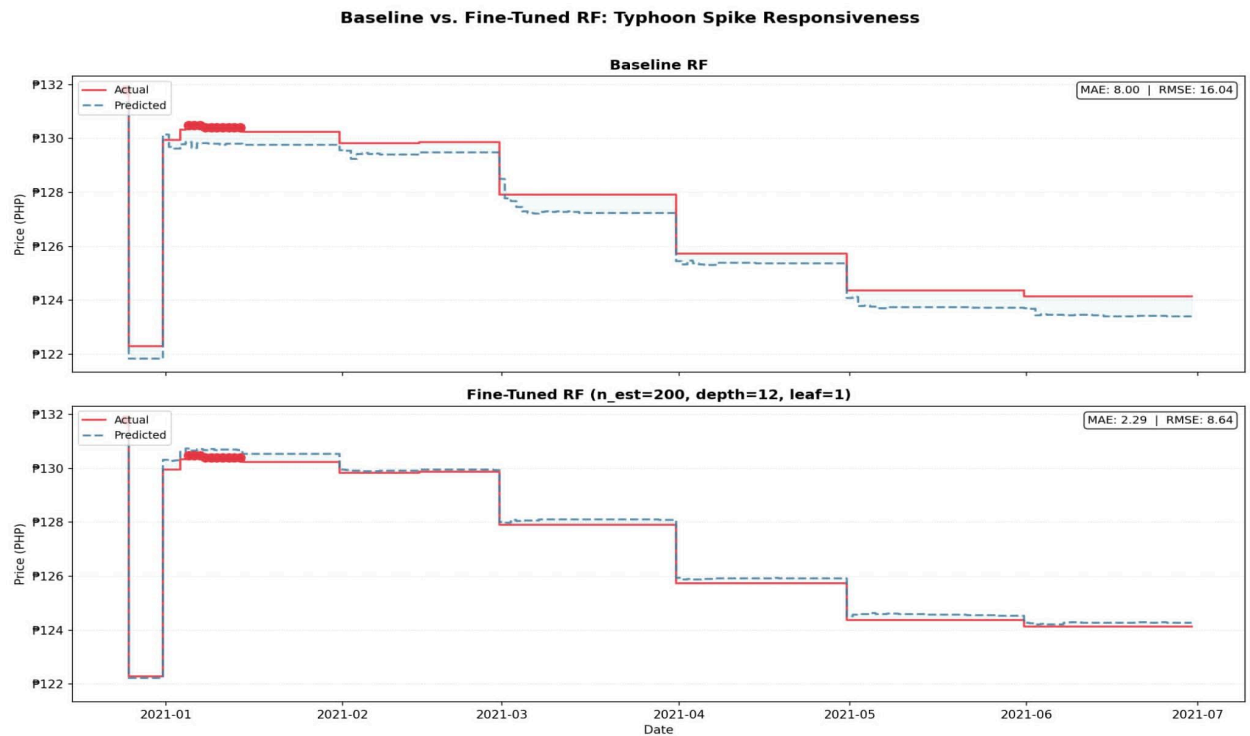


The feature importance chart reveals that `mp_price_lag14` is by far the most dominant predictor (~0.78 importance score), followed by `mp_price_lag7` (~0.12) and

3. Regional Food Security Risk Classification — K-Means Clustering (k=3)

- **At Risk** — Region III (Central Luzon) and Region IV-A (Calabarzon) recorded the highest price volatility scores, driven by heavy urban demand and their role as major food distribution hubs.
- **Vulnerable** — Regions VI, VII, IX, X, XI (Davao), XII (Soccsksargen), ARMM, and NCR showed structurally weak supply chains and low supply stability. Notably, NCR is classified as Vulnerable despite being the country's economic center, reflecting its complete dependence on external food sources.
- **Secure** — Regions I, II, IV, V, VIII, XIII, and CAR demonstrated moderate price volatility and resilient food systems, making them best positioned to withstand market disruptions.

4. Price Prediction — Baseline vs. Fine-Tuned Random Forest



Metric	Baseline RF	Fine-Tuned RF
MAE	₱ 8.00	₱ 2.29
RMSE	₱ 16.04	₱ 8.64

The Fine-Tuned Random Forest (n_est=200, depth=12, leaf=1) significantly outperformed the baseline model, achieving a 71.4% reduction in MAE and a 46.1% reduction in RMSE. By applying 3× sample weights to high-price spike events (top 5th percentile), the model became substantially more responsive to typhoon-driven price surges. As shown in the figure above, the fine-tuned model's predicted prices track the actual price curve far more closely across the entire January–July 2021 test period compared to the baseline, which consistently lagged during sharp price transitions.

These findings provide clear, data-driven guidance for policymakers to prioritize food security interventions in high-risk and vulnerable regions before price crises escalate.

Challenges and Solutions

- **Challenge:** Rolling weather averages initially caused data leakage by looking "forward" in time.
- **Solution:** Used the `.shift()` and `.transform()` functions to ensure rolling averages only used past historical data.

Conclusion

The project successfully developed a robust predictive and analytical framework for monitoring staple food prices across 17 regions in the Philippines. By processing over two decades of historical data (2000–2021), the team demonstrated that machine learning, specifically the Random Forest Regressor, is a highly effective tool for anticipating market fluctuations.

Key Takeaways:

- **Predictive Accuracy:** The implementation of a fine-tuned Random Forest model achieved a Mean Absolute Error (MAE) of approximately 8.00, indicating that the model can forecast prices with high reliability even amidst the inherent volatility of the agricultural market.
- **Driving Factors:** The analysis revealed that price momentum (7-day and 14-day lags) and environmental variables (14-day and 30-day rolling precipitation/temperature) are critical predictors. This confirms that food security in the Philippines is deeply intertwined with both market behavior and climate patterns.
- **Risk Identification:** The regional risk classification successfully categorized regions like Region XI (Davao) and Region XII (Soccsksargen) as "Vulnerable." This data-driven categorization provides actionable insights for policymakers to prioritize food price stabilization efforts and resource allocation in these specific areas.
- **Scalability:** Despite the computational challenges of handling 2.5 million records, the team successfully optimized the pipeline using strategic data sampling and efficient feature encoding, proving that the system is scalable for future real-time monitoring applications.

In summary, this project met all its primary objectives. It not only provides a high-performing model for price forecasting but also establishes a data-driven foundation for addressing regional food insecurity and price instability in the Philippines.